



POWER AND STRUGGLE: As Manmohan falters politically, Sonia has so far not been much of a help

achievement was initiating the engagement with America. It was Vajpayee who broke the spell of Third Worldism—which also meant anti-Americanism in certain quarters—and realised the possibilities of the post-Cold War World. He struck a perfect balance between national confidence and international responsibility. So, there could have been some meeting ground for BJP and the Congress on this issue. The so-called Third Front, though, is hoping that the opposition to a deal with America will only consolidate the rewards from the minority ghettos.

With the Congress not blinking, on Thursday last, the CPI(M) Central Committee reiterated the earlier decision of the Politburo against operationalising the deal. Later Karat

dropped hints that there would be no immediate withdrawal of support. But the announcement of public rallies all over the country, starting September 4, is proof that the Marxists were preparing the ground for an eventual pullout that would inevitably thrust an ill-timed poll on the country. The Reds' strategy seems to be to keep the Government on tenterhooks, to keep it in power while ensuring it has no real control.

What is unfolding at the moment, though, is the politics of bad coalition. Running a coalition is like playing a game of chess. When UPA and the Left began to play a friendly game, the now-defunct Common Minimum Programme was the rule book. As the game progressed, the rules were discarded. Today, the king in danger is certainly not the communist. It was perhaps inevitable. Historically, coalition hasn't been the Congress's idea of governance, though it may have supported governments at the Centre from outside. So there was no urgency to master the art of cohabitation. UPA is a bitter lesson for the Congress. Now the party is dangerously closer to the recklessness of outside support, for so long a Congress prerogative. This coalition test for the Congress may prove to be politically costlier than the nuclear test.

What India needs, though, is not a confluence of national rhetoric but a coalition of national responsibility.

DICTATORSHIP OF THE POLITBURO

An ideologically fossilised Left has never had it so good: the power to influence policies without any responsibility

Anger in the Left Front over Manmohan Singh's handling of the bilateral agreement is only rising. Despite moderate Bengali Marxists such as Jyoti Basu and West Bengal CPI(M) Secretary Biman Bose ruling out mid-term elections, and despite Pranab Mukherjee's frequent telephone calls to West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, Karat has wished death for the nuclear agreement. His counterpart in CPI, A.B. Bardhan, had predicted the inevitability of the Government's disintegration three months ago. Smaller Left constituents, RSP and Forward Bloc, have been complaining about the Congress for a while now. "To make India's foreign policy and strategic autonomy hostage to the potential of nuclear energy does not make sense except for the American imperative to bind India to its strategic designs in Asia," Karat wrote in a recent article in his party mouthpiece *People's Democracy*. "Only three per cent of our energy requirement will be met by the execution of this deal, and mind you, not before 2020," argues CPI(M) MP Tapan Sen. This is Karat's big fight against imperialism. He is willing to sacrifice power for ideology. With 59 MPs in the



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